

KEY HR INITIATIVES

► **Building Culture:** Establishing a company-wide system for employee feedback and working backwards from there to innovate and solve for issues

► **Diversity, Equity and Inclusion:** Going beyond gender to ensure that policies, hiring practices, reviews and facilities are inclusive for all employees

► **Talent Development:** Establishing leadership principles of 'Hire and Develop the Best' that encourage leaders to take their role in coaching others seriously

employees caring for a child with a developmental disability and has piloted various programmes to expand focus on employee well-being, including sensitising and training leaders to have a higher emotional quotient. Other initiatives such as 'hush-hours' for personal and professional tasks, curated content for employees coping with grief and a dedicated line for additional support are being piloted as well.

Amazon is also working towards providing opportunities to under-represented groups like women, LGBTQ+ individuals, veterans, and persons with disabilities. It has the 'Maternity Buddy' programme and work flexibility for new mothers; internal mentoring programmes such as Sunshine—that connects and supports women employees—and AmVoice, which addresses the concerns and queries of women employees and improves their experience. Its 'Rekindle' programme aims to help women who have taken a career break, while the global 'WiFi' programme focusses on recruiting, retaining, and advancing women in finance. Amazon also operates women-operated delivery partner service stations and an All-Women virtual customer service centre that provides opportunities for women to work from home.

It has also set up a silent delivery station in Mumbai run by individuals with speech and hearing impairment and developed a dedicated hiring website for military veterans and transitioning service personnel. To ensure that the LGBTQ+ community feels supported and valued, the company has taken several steps, including providing gender-neutral facilities and designing policies that are inclusive for same-gender partners. The company has also established 'Glamazon' affini-



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ty groups to support the LGBTQ+ community to foster healthy discussions at the workplace.

"When we talk about diversity at Amazon we include gender, disability, military status, sexual orientation and life experience, among others. Amazon's culture of inclusion is reinforced by our leadership principles, which remind team members to seek diverse perspectives, learn and be curious and lead with empathy. We take an intersectional approach to the policies, programmes and strategies we create for our employees to build inclusion into our culture," says Varma. Backed by these people initiatives, Amazon India has emerged as one of the top companies in the BT-Tagd Best Companies to Work For in India ranking this year.

To measure the success of various upskilling and well-being programmes, Amazon relies on metrics like Net Promoter Score (NPS), and How's My Driving (HMD), as well as qualitative anecdotes from

programme participants. Its real-time feedback platform 'Connections' allows employees to share their experiences in a confidential manner. The leadership team then reviews the data to design and execute interventions and address feedback. "At Amazon, we strive to cultivate a forward thinking, affirmative and empathy-led workplace. This, coupled with our deep focus on building a diverse and inclusive work culture, has helped us build mechanisms over the years to create a safer, more productive, higher performing and diverse work environment," says Varma.

The HR team at Amazon strives to stay true to its new moniker—the people experience and technology solutions team—through its relentless pursuit of innovative initiatives that create a happier and more fulfilling workplace for employees. **BT**

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